US leaders, however, did not ponder how their actions might be misunderstood in the Kremlin. They did not consider how misperception might lead to miscalculation and disaster. This is all the more surprising as one of the things that JFK is invariably (and understandably) given credit for, is thinking through how his adversary would see what Washington was doing.

Duck and cover

There was discussion about nuclear attacks against the United States from Cuba. On 23 October the Assistant Secretary of Defense for Civil Defense, Steuart Pittman, briefed ExComm. Some ninety-two million people, including in fifty-eight cities with populations of 100,000-plus, were estimated to be in range of the missiles (though as the range of the MRBMs was underestimated, so numbers would have been higher). [56] Prior to the meeting, Kennedy had told Roswell Gilpatric that 'if we were ever going to carry it out all the way [an attack on Cuba] we ought to have those cities evacuated'.[57] However, evacuations of US cities had never been planned or rehearsed.

The President wanted to know what could be done in anticipation of Soviet nuclear retaliation from Cuba involving '10 or 15 missiles' if 'say, five or six or seven days' notice' was given.[58] DCI McCone concluded from the discussion that 'not very much could or would be done', and that 'that whatever was done would involve a great deal of publicity and public alarm.'[59] When evacuation of cities in the South-East was raised in ExComm, Pittman explained that the only protection against nuclear fallout was in the cities – there was little or no protection in rural areas. In January 1962 he had issued a statement: 'Probable short warning time in the missile age and the increasing danger of fallout required that first priority in State and local survival planning be given to movement to shelters; or lacking shelters, to taking the best cover which is immediately available.'[60] This echoed the advice given to children by a cartoon reptile called Burt the Turtle, who told them of the need to 'duck and cover' in the event of